



Art,
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Generating the Identity Token

On the Measurement of the Self in the Age of Algorithmic Diagnosis

by Julia Thomas

“비어 있네”: You are the living void. Re-substantiating the relinquished self that was never yours to begin with.

I. The Scene

An apparatus stands in the room, clinical in its coolness. Visitors insert a saliva tube; LEDs flash and a loading bar crawls across a screen with occult metrics: Karmic Debt 33%, Quantum Entanglement 80%, Family Trauma Score 45%. At the end a pulsating ink blob appears, generated from parameters like NARC 0.73 and OEDIPAL 0.89. A performer in a white coat notes the values, nods knowingly, and delivers a pseudoscientific interpretation. The visitor listens. She believes it.

Despite the absurdity of the metrics and the impossibility of extracting an Oedipal Index from saliva, many visitors take the diagnosis seriously, not ironically but with a genuine willingness to recognize themselves in it. Developed for the exhibition “Helth”¹ on post-modern self-optimization, the installation is a satire that exceeds its own boundaries: what it dramatizes is the way contemporary subjects have learned to administer themselves as objects of measurement and optimization, a self-executed form of biopower.

II. The Pathology of Health

But the satire works only because the impulse it mocks is real. Why are we now so pre-occupied with optimizing ourselves? Consider orthorexia nervosa,² a term coined in 1997 for an obsessive fixation on “pure” eating. What is remarkable is that the pursuit of wellness, taken to its extreme, produces illness: the orthorexic is not indifferent to health but too devoted to it; the sickness is an excess of the cure, health pursued until it harms.

That such attention can become pathological, and has even been proposed for inclusion in the diagnostic manual,³ already shows that diagnosis does not merely describe a

condition but helps constitute it. The question is not whether the measurement is valid, obviously not, but why we have become the kind of people for whom any measurement feels like an answer to who we are.

III. The Willingness to Be Diagnosed

Part of the answer lies in the authority we grant to measurement, which goes nearly unquestioned: what can be measured exists. The Quantified Self carries its motto in its name, self-knowledge through numbers, and Lupton⁴ describes how data comes to be considered “truer” than lived experience. The authority of the white coat is older, Foucault’s link between knowledge and power, though it is partly staging: props that establish authority before a word is spoken. The visitors know this and play along anyway, because a diagnosis promises explanation, classification, identity.

IV. Making Up People

But a diagnosis does more than promise; it produces. This is Hacking’s looping effect⁵: diagnoses create the people they describe. These kinds of people are “moving targets,” because our investigations interact with and change them. The classic case is Multiple Personality Disorder, now Dissociative Identity Disorder; the renaming reshaped the symptoms, and the symptoms confirmed the diagnosis. The same logic echoes in algorithmic attribution: more than half of ADHD-related TikTok videos are scientifically inaccurate,⁶ yet many users report recognizing themselves. Alper et al.⁷ call this algorithmically mediated biographical illumination; TikTok does not merely inform its users, it shapes how they understand themselves.

V. Diagnosis Without Etiology

And it shapes without explaining anything, because psychiatric diagnosis is descriptive, not etiological: the DSM describes symptom clusters but does not explain causes. “Depression” says nothing about why one is depressed. Allen Frances,⁸ chair of the DSM-IV Task Force, warns of a “diagnostic exuberance” that confuses disorder with ordinary sadness; the deeper problem is reification, treating a descriptive convention as if it

named natural entities. What purpose does diagnosis serve if it explains nothing? Billing, administration, research, treatment. In this sense, diagnosis functions as a tool of governance.

VI. From Discipline to Control

To see how it governs, trace the genealogy of power. Foucault described a shift from sovereign power, which punished the body, to disciplinary power, which produced docile bodies through observation: the Panopticon's point was not that the guard always watched but that the inmate, never knowing, policed himself. Biopower extended this from the body to the population; life itself (health, productivity, reproduction) became the object of administration.

Self-measurement marks a further turn. The disciplinary gaze required an external watcher, the biopolitical regime institutions; in self-measurement this externality collapses. The watcher is the app on the wrist, the clinic the saliva tube on the counter. We have internalized the warden so thoroughly that we pay to install him in our pockets. Neoliberalism, Foucault's late lectures⁹ show, produces homo oeconomicus as "entrepreneur of himself." Han¹⁰ names its affective form "psychopolitics": power through positive incitement, experienced as freedom.

Deleuze¹¹ extends this: where discipline operated through enclosures, control operates through continuous modulation, and individuals become "dividuals." Classical statistics sought the norm; algorithmic governance is devoid of relation to the norm; its goal is not normalization but prediction. Everyone is a risk profile, and the self-tracking subject is not only the addressee of biopower but its raw material.

VII. The Inductive Turn and Theory-Ladenness

That raw material feeds a new epistemology. In 2008 Chris Anderson proclaimed "The End of Theory":¹² with enough data the scientific method becomes obsolete, "correlation supersedes causation." The parallel to psychiatry is striking: just as the DSM describes without explaining, Big Data correlates without understanding. But numbers do not speak for themselves; as Kuhn¹³ showed, there is no neutral observation language. The apps

and wearables that quantify us are not neutral recorders but apparatuses that constitute phenomena: their categories (sleep quality, stress, productivity) precede the measurement. We do not discover who we are; we are fitted into prefabricated categories that echo a hegemonic system with its own incentives.

VIII. The Hidden Theory of Control

If no measurement is ever neutral, what theory underlies the supposedly theory-free inductive turn? Its function: control. A theory that explains can be contested: “you are depressed because of a chemical imbalance” invites counter-evidence. But take “you score 0.73 on the depression index”: what is there to contest? The number simply is. By refusing to explain, the system immunizes itself against critique and hides its constitutive power.

The deeper claim is that prediction is structurally identical with control. A model cannot predict an individual; it can only assign her to a class of similar cases and transfer the class’s behavior. Prediction is always prediction-in-groups: nothing can be said of you that was not first said of a cluster to which you were assimilated. And every model is built against an objective function: it minimizes a loss with respect to a target such as click-through, conversion, retention, or recidivism. Every “neutral” correlation is a correlation with respect to a criterion of success. The hidden theory is not in the categories the system reports; it is in the loss function it never reveals.

To know is therefore to be able to modulate: a prediction that changes nothing is, by the system’s standards, a failed prediction. Knowledge and control are a single act, and to be datafied is to be reduced from a who to a what: a target, a profile. The groups produced are operational, not sociological: clusters that behave alike toward a target variable, sold to advertisers, insurers, lenders, campaigns. The looping effect now runs at industrial scale: the segment is built to be sold, the sale refines it, the subject is invited to recognize herself in its predicted preferences. The category that cannot be argued with cannot be refused, and the deficiency it names is one a market is already prepared to supply.

There is therefore no innocent metric: the subject endlessly processed becomes not more known but more empty.

IX. Language Constitutes Its Object

This emptiness is no accident. Just as theory constitutes its object, the subject is constituted through language; there is no language-free self, and so algorithmic self-knowledge is structurally impossible: the self the apparatus claims to measure is already constituted by the categories that purport to describe it. The ADHD diagnosis shapes how one experiences one's own attention; the subject becomes what it is named. Where Foucault's clinic produced its hysterics over decades, the platform produces diagnostic identities in weeks: the mechanism is continuous, the time signature new.

X. The Closed Loop

The installation stages precisely this. It makes visible what algorithmic systems hide: the closed loop of measurement and constitution. The visitors find meaning because the readiness for self-recognition through external attribution is so deeply anchored that even obvious nonsense functions as a mirror. As Lacan¹⁴ understood, the subject is constituted through the gaze of the Other; we need something outside ourselves to tell us who we are. The installation offers the form of recognition without its substance: the apparatus of being-seen, but with no one who sees.

Descartes' "I think, therefore I am" becomes: I measure, therefore I am. I am what my trackers know about me, and they know me as an entrepreneur of myself. These metrics return as advertising and consumer categories, what Lupton calls exploited self-tracking: the same data with which I believe I am knowing myself categorizes me as a target audience. The Panopticon has been monetized, and the inmate has become the shareholder of his own surveillance.

The subject is constitutively split, a stranger to itself by condition, not defect. Self-measurement promises to overcome this alienation but deepens it instead, not by conspiracy but by structural affinity: a subject at home in itself resists manipulation, while an uncertain subject, perpetually seeking itself, is available for management and consumption.

Into each new gap flow the offers: the diagnosis with its drug, the personality type with its community. None of these can finally satisfy, because what the subject seeks is the Other who sees and is changed by the encounter. The circle closes: alienation produces neediness, neediness is filled with offers, the offers produce new alienation. The system does not invent our lack; it administers it. The visitor leaves clutching a token simultaneously hers and utterly foreign: processed, not met.

XI. Orthorexia

Orthorexia is where this logic becomes flesh, and it is no accident that it emerges precisely now. Eating disorders have always been about regaining control in times of change, but orthorexia is the disorder of the quantified self, speaking the language of optimization and purity rather than restriction and thinness. Orthorexics do not merely control food; they measure it, submitting the body to the same datafication that pervades every other domain. The subject whose coordinates (stable work, relationships, identity) are dissolving turns to the one domain that still seems manageable: the body and its numbers.

But the coordinates dissolve because social bonds are dissolving in late modernity; we are increasingly alone, even as consciousness emerged from communication and is oriented toward it. Without the Other, there is no self, and what we receive instead is the pseudosocial, the form of connection without its substance. This is why we cling to measurement: the body remains, the step count remains, the health score remains, small dominions, pathetic perhaps, but ours. The visitor submits to absurd measurement not despite its absurdity but because any external attribution feels better than the void. The tragedy of the quantified self is not that measurement is inaccurate but that it is accepted as a substitute for what cannot be measured, and so the subject measures itself endlessly, hoping the next metric will tell it who it is, while the answer lies in an encounter no algorithm can provide. The installation knows this, and hands each visitor not a verdict but an empty token.

비어 있 는: empty, and therefore open.

Julia Thomas is a ML Engineer and behavioral psychotherapist, PhD in clinical psychology and epidemiology in Basel, art practice for Semantic ai and philosophy lab residing at the beautiful Prachtsaal Studios e.V.

¹ “Helth” (Culterim Veterinary, 2024, <https://pascal.cc/helth>).

² Steven Bratman coined the term in “Health Food Junkie,” *Yoga Journal* (1997). For proposed clinical criteria see Dunn, T. M., & Bratman, S. (2016). On orthorexia nervosa: A review of the literature and proposed diagnostic criteria. *Eating Behaviors*, 21, 11–17.

³ American Psychiatric Association (2013). *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders* (5th ed.). Orthorexia is not a recognized DSM-5 diagnosis; only proposed criteria exist (Dunn & Bratman, 2016).

⁴ Lupton, D. (2016). *The Quantified Self*. Cambridge: Polity Press.

⁵ Hacking, I. (1995). The looping effects of human kinds. In D. Sperber, D. Premack, & A. J. Premack (Eds.), *Causal Cognition*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. See also Hacking, “Making Up People” (1986).

⁶ Yeung, A., Ng, E., & Abi-Jaoude, E. (2022). TikTok and attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder: A cross-sectional study of social media content quality. *Canadian Journal of Psychiatry*, 67(12),

⁷ Alper, M., Rauchberg, J. S., Simpson, E., Guberman, J., & Feinberg, S. (2023). TikTok as algorithmically mediated biographical illumination: Autism, self-discovery, and platformed diagnosis on #autisttok. *New Media & Society*, 27(3), 1378–1396. (The study concerns autism; the concept is extended here to algorithmic self-attribution more broadly.)

⁸ Frances, A. (2013). *Saving Normal*. New York: William Morrow.

⁹ Foucault, M. (2008). *The Birth of Biopolitics: Lectures at the Collège de France, 1978–1979*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.

¹⁰ Han, B.-C. (2017). *Psychopolitics: Neoliberalism and New Technologies of Power*. London: Verso.

¹¹ Deleuze, G. (1992). Postscript on the societies of control. *October*, 59, 3–7.

¹² Anderson, C. (2008). The end of theory: The data deluge makes the scientific method obsolete. *Wired*.

¹³ Kuhn, T. S. (1962). *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

¹⁴ Lacan, J. (1978). *The Four Fundamental Concepts of Psychoanalysis* (Seminar XI). New York: Norton. See also *Écrits*.